Activity 13
Positive relationships – building rapport

Purpose

To recognise key rapport-building skills and to practise using them.

Activity 13
Positive relationships – building rapport

Introduction

Difficult and aggressive behaviour may be a response to a communication breakdown. Effective communicators establish rapport naturally in any situation. We all establish rapport naturally with people that we know well. This activity provides an opportunity to consider key rapport-building skills and to practise them.

Purpose

To recognise key rapport-building skills and to practise using them.

Application

Building rapport is fundamental to all effective communication. This activity can be used on a programme on Dealing with Difficult and Aggressive Behaviour. It is short and fairly light-hearted so it can be used to change the pace of the programme and break up the day. It can also be used on any management development programme or Communication Skills programme.

What happens

Following a brief introduction to the key rapport-building skills of mirroring, matching, pacing and leading, the participants practise using these skills to establish and build rapport.

The activity closes by introducing opportunities to practise these skills.

Time

Overall time required: 40 minutes

- Introduction: 5 minutes
- An introduction to building rapport: 10 minutes
- Pacing and leading – exercise: 10 minutes
- Group discussion: 10 minutes
- Summary and close: 5 minutes

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Materials & resources

- 3 OHT masters:
  13.1 *Building rapport*
  13.2 *Ways of matching/mirroring*
  13.3 *Flowchart for pacing and leading*

- 2 Handout masters:
  13.4 *Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading*
  13.5 *Pacing and leading – exercise brief*

- 1 Trainer's brief
  13.6 *Building rapport*

- Overhead projector, or PowerPoint® compatible laptop computer and projector, and screen
- Flipchart and stand or whiteboard
- Marker pens for trainer
- Paper and pens for participants
- Space for pairs and small-group work (preferably separate syndicate rooms for the small-group work or, if these are not available, you can divide the area with screens)

In preparation

It would be a good idea to familiarise yourself with the material on **Trainer's brief 13.6** *Building rapport*, before running this activity.

How do I do it?

INTRODUCTION

Start by introducing the purpose of the activity, which is:

- to recognise key rapport-building skills
- to practise using them.

Invite the participants to tell the whole group what they know of rapport-building skills. Do not note them down, just acknowledge them as they are offered. Skills mentioned may include:

- mirroring
- matching
- pacing and leading
- eye contact
- body language
- representational systems
- accessing cues.

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Not all these skills may be mentioned and you do not need to list them. If participants want to know, briefly, what these skills involve, ask the group to tell each other what they currently understand of these skills.

Tell the participants that this activity focuses on:

- mirroring
- matching
- pacing and leading.

Allow 5 minutes for this brief introduction.

AN INTRODUCTION TO BUILDING RAPPORT

Tell the participants that, in establishing rapport, we create an environment of trust, confidence and participation. Development of rapport skills allows you to get and maintain a sense of co-operation with another person. Furthermore, effective use of these skills greatly increases your confidence and makes it easier for others to communicate with you.

Show OHT 13.1
Building rapport

Talk through this OHT which will introduce the concept of building rapport to the participants. Ask if any of the participants are familiar with the concepts – some may be. If not, ask if the contents of the OHT make sense (they will do to the vast majority!). You may have one or two sceptics; ask them to save their points until they have completed the exercise.

It is possible that a participant will point out that matching, pacing and leading can be misused, to persuade people to buy things they do not want, for example. You have to acknowledge this, agree with the point, stating that this activity is about practising the skills so that the participants can deal more effectively with difficult and aggressive behaviour.

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Voice tonality refers to the pitch, the quality and the strength of voice used. So, if someone is speaking slowly, not very loudly, and at mid pitch (not too high and squeaky, not too gruff and low), if you wanted to match them you would try and match that tone, rather than speaking loudly, fast and at a high pitch. Breathing refers to the rate of breathing – with practice, you can become expert at noticing if someone is breathing fast (frequently the case in people who are anxious); you would only match them if you later wanted to lead them to a slower pace (see later in this activity).

Use Handout 13.4 Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading, for further information. The participants need to have a clear idea of ways of matching, pacing and leading so that they can practise them in the exercise.

Show OHT 13.2
Ways of matching/mirroring

This OHT introduces the participants to the processes they need to use in the exercise. When you are satisfied that the participants recognise the skills they need to use, show the following OHT which provides a quick, visual summary of the process.

Show OHT 13.3
Flowchart for pacing and leading

This flowchart is self-explanatory – if the other person does not accept your lead, go back to pacing and try leading later. Tell the participants that the timescale for this can be as little as 30 seconds, or you could spend up to 2 to 3 minutes pacing, before you start to lead. This will depend upon your level of skill and how willing the other person is to accept your lead; some people will consciously reject it.

Allow about 10 minutes for this brief introduction to building rapport and for participants' questions.

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Distribute Handout 13.4
Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading

PACING AND LEADING – EXERCISE

This is a quick, fairly light-hearted exercise that is fun to do. It is an opportunity for the participants to practise pacing and leading. The participants will work in threes to practise the skills and to consider their next steps. The brief does not state that there will be three rounds, with each participant taking the three roles in turn, but if you decide to do this, it will take longer.

Distribute Handout 13.5
Pacing and leading – exercise brief

Read through this exercise brief with the participants and check that it is clear to everyone. Then, form the participants into groups of three (see the section on Small groups in *How to use this resource*, on page xi).

If you have a participant group that is not divisible by three, you will have a four – two observers.

Your role is to be available to respond to any questions that participants may have.

Allow 10 minutes for this exercise.

GROUP DISCUSSION

Once the exercise has been completed, reconvene as a whole group and invite the participants to respond to the following questions:

Question 1
How did it go?

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Question 2
What do you need to do to develop these skills (and what feedback or review mechanisms will you use to check out your effectiveness)?

Question 3
How do you think you will be able to use these skills?

You do not need a response from each participant to each point – this is a whole-group discussion to reinforce the learning.

Typical responses to Question 1

- it went OK
- I need more practice
- I need to read and consider the handout
- went well/was fun/was difficult
- observers were useful
- feedback was helpful
- amazing what a difference it makes.

Typical responses to Question 2

- practice, practice, practice
- read the handout
- become more familiar
- test myself out
- actively review how I get on by practising out of work, for example, at parties or in the pub.

Typical responses to Question 3

- use the skills in all situations where I want to communicate effectively, especially when someone is getting upset/angry/having difficulties.

Allow 10 minutes for this brief discussion.

SUMMARY AND CLOSE

Once those participants who want to offer some feedback have had an opportunity to do so, summarise the learning by stating that we all match naturally those we know well and that we can all

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develop these skills to use with those we do not know well. We can practise throughout life, during the rest of this programme, and during the breaks. We can effectively lead someone 'down' from the start of difficult or aggressive behaviour – it is one skill to have available.

Allow no more than 5 minutes for your summary and close.

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Building rapport

- **We all build rapport naturally.**
- **To build rapport, you need to develop your flexibility of thought and behaviour.**
- **When people get on well, they tend to match body language, voice tonality, breathing.**
- **When people are in disagreement they tend to mismatch body language, voice tonality, breathing.**

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Ways of matching/mirroring

Whole body matching	**Adjust your body to match their stance.**
Half body matching	**Match the upper or lower portion of their body.**
Head/shoulders	**Match typical positions of their head and/or shoulders.**
Facial expressions	**Match the way that they use their face, for example, smile, raise their eyebrows.**
Gestures	**Match their gestures, for example, position/use of hands.**
Voice quality	**Match tone, speed, volume, pitch.**
Repetitive phrasing	**Note and match in your own words their repeated phrases. For example, if they use the expression 'Know what I mean?' repeatedly, try using 'Am I being clear?'**
Breathing	**Adjust your own breathing to their rhythm.**

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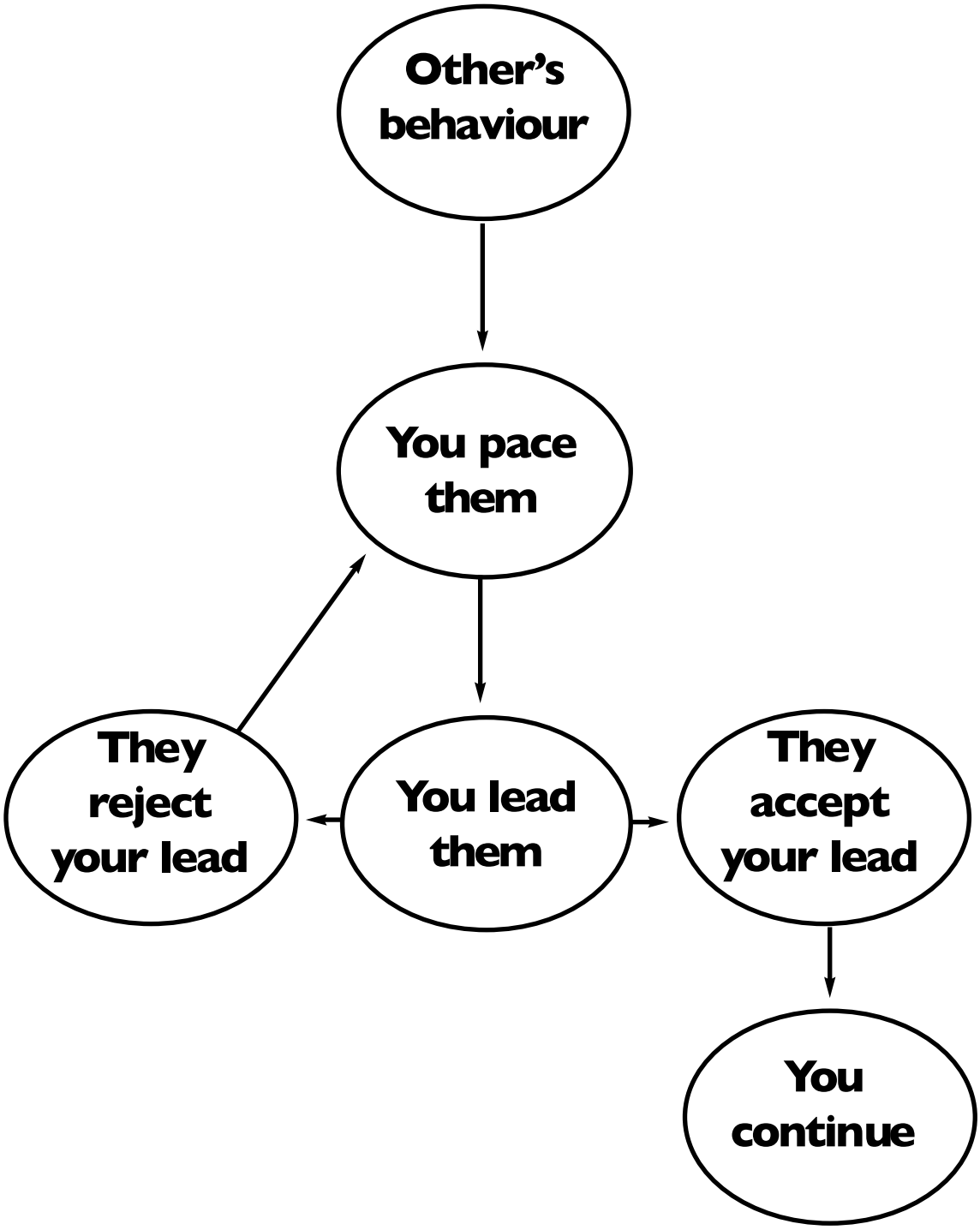
Flowchart for pacing and leading



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Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading

Mirroring/matching

If you look at people in public places, you can probably tell which groups are friends and which are not. Groups of friends, those groups in good rapport, will be responding to each other in subtle ways; they may even be unaware of their responses. You will notice, however, that the movements of one person will be echoed or mirrored by another, or others in the group. For example, one person stands tall/straightens up, the person they are talking to will do the same. One person slouches, the person they are talking to will slouch also. This process, which is quite natural to most of us, is called mirroring.

Pacing

Mirroring/matching can be developed and practised, as a means of rapidly establishing rapport at an unconscious level. This is called pacing, in the sense that you are pacing the other person – joining their pace, rather than forcing your own. It is a way of establishing rapport and trying to understand another person by joining in their experience of the world.

For example, your experience of the office party will be very different depending on whether: you sit down, legs and arms crossed; stand at the bar, in the thick of it; dance all evening; or if you are pinned in a corner by the office bore.

The outcome of effective pacing will be your ability to establish rapport with whoever you choose. Be subtle and respectful in your pacing so that what you do does not intrude or become mimicry.

Leading

Leading means that once you have established rapport, you make subtle changes in your own behaviour to cause the other person to follow your lead.

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Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading

… continued

For example, sit next to someone who has chosen to 'sit out' at a party/conference/seminar, away from other people, crossed arms and legs, quite a closed posture. Mirror their posture and gestures and their breathing. Talk with them; slowly unfold yourself (uncross your arms, legs, start using more open hand gestures and movements) and, changing your breathing, see how they respond. If you have successfully led them, try standing up and see if they follow (without inviting them to do so verbally). There are untold opportunities for practice – be creative!

Rapport

Choose who you want to get into rapport with; some may not want to (this may be the case if you are dealing with difficult and aggressive behaviour).

You may want to use your rapport skills to signal that the meeting has ended; we all do this, in unconscious ways, by changing our pace of speaking, moving away slightly, to signal the ending, and so on.

Ways of matching/mirroring

- Whole body matching – adjust your body to match their stance.
- Half-body matching – match the upper or lower portion of their body.
- Head/shoulders – match typical positions of their head and/or shoulders.
- Facial expressions – match the way that they use their face, for example, smile, raise their eyebrows.
- Gestures – match their gestures, for example, position/use of hands.
- Voice quality – match tone, speed volume, pitch.

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Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading

… continued

- Repetitive phrasing – note and match in your own words their repeated phrases. For example, if they use the expression, 'Know what I mean?', repeatedly, try using, 'Am I being clear?'.

- Breathing – adjust your own breathing to their rhythm.

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Pacing and leading – exercise brief

The aim of this exercise is for you to practise the skills of pacing and leading another person into a different style of communication.

- **Pacing:** gaining and maintaining rapport for a while, while interacting with another person, using mirroring and matching, joining their pace.

- **Leading:** having established rapport, making subtle changes in your behaviour so that the other person follows your lead.

You will work in groups of three. Choose who will be client/customer, manager, and observer.

Client/customer

You need to think of a situation that is real to you, and fill the manager in on the background, including your own feelings at the time. For example, this could be when you did not get what you wanted from a staff member in a shop or a restaurant; where you were badly treated and became angry.

You are getting fed up with getting nowhere with your problem. When the manager intervenes, you are still angry and tell them so.

Manager

You are the manager of the staff member who was originally involved. The client/customer's situation is new to you, but you are seeing what you can do to assist the client/customer with their problem. Find out what the problem is, listening carefully, matching posture, gestures, voice qualities as your exploration of the problem progresses. When you feel that you have established rapport, then change your behaviour subtly, so that you lead the client/customer into a different style of communication.

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Pacing and leading – exercise brief

… *continued*

Observer

Observe closely the behaviour of both people, so that you can give feedback to the manager on how they managed to match, pace and lead the client/customer in this 'meeting'.

You have 5 minutes for speaking/matching and 5 minutes for feedback.

Review

Take 5 minutes and in your group, discuss the following:

- How successful was the manager?
- What reactions did you observe to the matching behaviour and then the leading behaviour?
- What do you need to do to develop your skills in this area?
- How will you know how you are doing?

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Building rapport

This Trainer's brief provides some very brief information on building rapport. The key rapport-building skills, apart from listening, are:

- mirroring
- matching
- pacing and leading
- eye contact
- body language
- representational systems
- accessing cues.

The first three are dealt with in some detail in Handout 13.4 Establishing rapport – matching, pacing and leading. Eye contact and body language are dealt with in *Activity 10 Non-verbal behaviour*.

Representational systems

We all make sense of the world in a range of ways. If you listen to people speaking, you can tell which representational system(s) they use to make sense of the world. There are five key representational systems:

- visual (seeing)
- auditory (hearing)
- kinaesthetic (feeling)
- gustatory (taste)
- olfactory (smell).

The last two are not much used by the majority of people. The clues you can use to identify which system(s) someone is using include the words or phrases they use. Rapport will be increased if you match their system.

So, for example, if you have identified that someone is very visual and they use words and phrases such as: get the picture, in the light of, it's clear that, looks like, clear, appear, glimpse, you can use visual words and/or phrases to match their representational system.

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Building rapport

… *continued*

Auditory people will use words and phrases such as: clear as a bell, loud and clear, word for word, hush, remark, tell, tone, vocal.

Kinaesthetic people will use words and phrases such as: firm foundation, come to grips with, hand in hand, smooth operator, if it feels right, heavy handed, handle, grasp, structured, tension, unbearable, lukewarm.

Many participants will have experienced a situation in a two-way conversation, and the other person says, 'You are just not listening to me – you keep missing the point'. This may well be due to a mismatch of representational systems (or it may be that they were just not listening).

Accessing cues

Further evidence of how people make sense of the world is provided by how people move their eyes.

If we are thinking of visual things, we will look up (sometimes straight ahead). If we are thinking of sounds we move our eyes sideways (towards our ears). If we are thinking of feelings or inner dialogue, we move our eyes downwards. You can observe this in other people, and observe the extent to which eye movements match the words and/or phrases people are using.

If participants want opportunities to develop these skills, you will have to suggest another training course – representational systems will probably be covered in a course on Neuro Linguistic Programming (NLP), as will accessing cues.

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